CONTENTMENT IN OUTER SPACE

Science Fiction / Philosophical Romance

Her name was Maria, although she called herself Morticia.

She sat quietly by herself, smoking a cigarette and staring into nowhere, to anyone else, perhaps there was nothing unusual about her. But something about the way she sat there made me think she was sad. More than sad, actually. It looked as though she were doing everything she could to keep herself from crying.

I didn't know why, but I suddenly felt an overwhelming need to speak to her.

"You go ahead," I told my friends. "I'll catch up later."

They looked at me with some surprise, but eventually continued without me. I approached her.

"Hello. You're Morticia, aren't you?"

"Yeah."

"Would you mind if I sat beside you? I won't be offended if you say no. And I have absolutely no intention of hurting you in any way."

She looked at me, then she smiled and gave a quiet laugh.

"That's a strange way to start a conversation."

I waited.

"But sure. Sit down."

"Thank you."

I sat beside her, we made some small talk for a while. She asked me what was going on, and I did my best to respond as naturally as possible, eventually, she turned toward me.

"Can I ask you something?"

"Anything." I said

"We've studied together for years."

I looked at her, and she continues

"You've never even said hello to me. Even when we've sat near each other, you've never spoken to me unless you had to. So why did you suddenly decide to talk to me today?"

She looked directly into my eyes, as I was contemplating the question.

"I don't really know."

She waited for the rest.

"I saw you sitting here. You looked sad. I couldn't just leave you like that."

Her expression changed slightly.

"So you felt sorry for me?"

"I don't think it was a pity." I said firmly

"What was it, then?" She asked me with a bit of curiosity

That was considerably more difficult to answer,I was still learning that humans had words for emotions they themselves struggled to define.

"I just didn't want to leave you like this."

She studied me for a moment,then we got up and began walking together.

I found myself looking at her occasionally as we walked.

"Why are you sad?" I asked. "If you don't mind me asking."

"It's complicated."

"Most things seem to be." I said and she almost smiled, and then she responded with a gloomy tone saying

"I don't think anyone would understand."

"Try me." I said while trying to sound optimistic and I said it confidently and gave her what I hoped looked like a warm smile, she was quiet for a moment.

"All right. You don't look like one, but... are you religious?"

"Not really. I consider myself more of a man of science."

I paused.

"But I'll try to keep an open mind this time."

She took another drag from her cigarette.

"I'm not completely committed to any particular religion," she said. "But I believe in God. And I believe in fate. Everything moves according to some precise order, the way it was meant to."

That caught my attention.

"Doesn't that mean we have no free will? If everything has already been decided from the beginning?"

"I don't know."

For the first time since we had begun talking, she seemed less interested in hiding her sadness than in answering the question.

"For a while, I thought we were the only creatures in the universe capable of choosing our own destinies. But the more I thought about it, the bigger the question became. I think it's beyond what a mortal mind can really understand."

"How?"

"Imagine you're an all-knowing, all-powerful being who exists everywhere."

I listened carefully.

"Time wouldn't work the same way for you. Maybe it wouldn't apply to you at all. You'd see every possibility and every alternative at once. So just because fate exists doesn't necessarily mean you're being forced to do anything."

I went silent.

Not because I disagreed.

Because I had genuinely never considered it that way.

"That's fascinating."

She glanced at me.

"I've never thought about it like that before."

"Neither had I, once."

She looked ahead as we continued walking.

"But while I was thinking about all this, I started noticing something else."

"What?"

"History repeats itself."

I waited.

"You get trapped in the same cycle. The details change a little, maybe the people change, but somehow you end up facing the same thing again. And fate doesn't let you out until you understand what you're supposed to learn from it."

She took a final drag from her cigarette.

"I think that's the point. Eventually, after everything that happens to you, you find out what kind of person you really are."

"And how is that working out for you?"

She didn't answer immediately.

There was something strange about the silence that followed. I had come to Earth to study humanity. That was my purpose here, to observe them. Understand them, record what I discovered and report it to my crew. yet sitting beside Morticia, I began to suspect there was a flaw in that approach, perhaps you could study a human being for a thousand years and still understand nothing about them, perhaps understanding them required something else entirely, I liked talking to her, she made me discover things not only about her world, but about myself and mine. Life seemed completely different whenever she was beside me. My first day in this new world eventually came to an end. I had no idea how long I would have to remain on Earth, but for the first time, staying here didn't seem so terrible. In fact, I found myself strangely eager to learn more about the human mind.

A week later, I realised I had spent most of my time on Earth with Morticia, I sat at the computer sending encrypted reports to my crew, documenting everything I had discovered, and as soon as I finished my report, I was going to see her again.